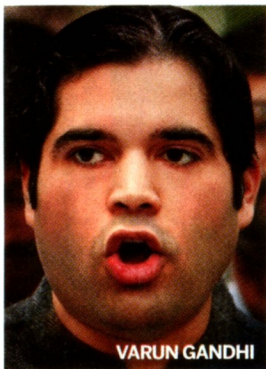


GANDHIGIRI

Varun Gandhi's political baptism has not gone according to the script. The BJP candidate from Pilibhit, Uttar Pradesh, is under fire for allegedly targeting Muslims in a campaign speech. Varun's comments have embarrassed the party which is trying hard to

AP



VARUN GANDHI

shed its communal image. While the BJP "disapproves" of his comments, Varun himself remained unapologetic. "I never made any communal comments," he says, claiming that the CD on air was doctored. The Election Commission, meanwhile, has sought explanations from both Varun and the BJP. The BJP certainly wasn't ready for this brand of Gandhigiri when it gave this Gandhi scion a ticket. *by Priya Sahgal*

BHARATIYA
JANSHAKTI
PARTY CHIEF
UMA BHARATI

8,727
firearm licences were issued in Punjab in the six months leading to the polls, leaving many wondering whether political parties were preparing for elections or for war.

BJP Sudden Turnaround

PANKAJ TIWARI



Temperamental sanyasin Uma Bharati, who had a bitter parting of ways with the BJP, has done a sudden and surprising turnaround. She has pledged support for L.K. Advani and declared that her party, Bharatiya Janshakti, will not field candidates against the BJP. She will also campaign for Advani and the party in non-BJP ruled states. For the strife-ridden BJP, this is indeed a welcome news. Bharati claims to be supporting Advani selflessly, "without wanting to join the BJP or the NDA". "No politician can match Advani's stature. I am supporting him for personal reasons as he is a father figure to me. He also has a very clean image. There are ideological reasons as well, since my party is said to have a soft corner for the BJP," she said recently.

by Bhavna Vij-Aurora

DEEPA DASMUNSI



SUBIR HALDER

No Friendly Fight

A seat-sharing agreement doesn't mean one party will dictate other's candidate. But when the Congress picked up Deepa Dasmunsi, wife of the ailing Priyaranjan as its candidate in Raiganj, West Bengal, Mamata Banerjee was not too happy. She got one of her partymen and an eight-term MLA A.K. Choudhury to quit and contest as an Independent. This will certainly be no friendly fight. *by Priya Sahgal*